shock to Dost Mohammad, who had believed that he and the Governor General were on excellent terms. In response he decided to appeal to Russia as diplomatic insurance in case the British made any further attempts to interfere in Afghanistan. ‘Afghanistan’s independence is threatened by British expansion,’ he wrote to the Tsar. ‘This expansion is also a threat to Russian trade in Central Asia and the surrounding countries to the south of it. Should Afghanistan be defeated in its lone struggle against Britain, it would also mean the end of Russia’s trade with Bokhara.’[23]

Vitkevitch stumbled across Mirza Hussein Ali when he took lodgings in the same Bukhara caravanserai and, realising the opportunity, offered personally to escort the Ambassador first to Orenburg, then on to St Petersburg. ‘Dost Mohammed Khan, the ruler of Kabulistan, is seeking the patronage of Russia,’ he reported excitedly, ‘and is prepared to do anything we ask for.’

First, however, he had to fight his away out of Bukhara, as the Amir had abruptly placed sentries around his lodgings, confiscated his camels and refused him permission to leave. ‘I grabbed my pistols,’ he wrote later,

> and thrust them beneath my belt, threw a coat over my shoulders, donned my travelling fur cap and ran to the Koosh Begee. As I entered, I realized they were talking about me and my departure, although I did not listen carefully. I ran straight into the room . . . [and said:] ‘I am telling you once again, and this is final, that for the life of me I shall not remain here and anyone who dares detain me on my way or even enquire of my destination, as I have already told you and a hundred of others who never stopped bothering me about it, anyone who stands in my way shall have the following reply’ – here I threw off the flap on my coat and pointed at the pistols. The Koosh Begee was so astonished he did not know what to say. I requested that he should give me a laissez-passer bearing his own seal, so that nobody would dare stop me, but he would not give me one, just said: go. I bid him farewell and left, repeating once again that a bullet would be my answer to anyone who provoked me on my way, be it with one word only. The Koosh Begee could not entirely keep up his pretence and said ‘We shall see’ – but he appeared pleased to see me leave.[24]

Over the months that followed, Vitkevitch and Hussein Ali made their way slowly through the steppe to Orenburg, and then on across the length of Russia to St Petersburg. Hussein Ali was struck down with dysentery on the road, but Vitkevitch nursed and encouraged him, using the enforced periods of rest to learn fluent Dari from his companion. The two finally arrived in the capital in March 1837. Vitkevitch had left Europe fourteen years earlier as a chained convict. This time, Tsar Nicholas personally sent him